or “post-industrial.” Government strategists tried to make the best out of fuel scarcities, promoting green agriculture and bicycle use. They also tried to find different ways forward, taking advantage of Cuba’s greatest strength, its highly educated population. The government promoted biotechnology, health tourism, educational tourism, and the export of doctors.

Although Cuba’s system of land tenure was changed in the 1990s, the agrarian reforms of the 1960s were not exactly reversed. In terms of peasant access to land, the 1993 reform actually put more land into the hands of small farmers, by dismantling the state farms and turning them into cooperatives or small plots. The Cuban state also continued to provide easy access to credit and to technical assistance – benefits that structural adjustment programs generally restricted.

Other inputs became a lot harder to come by, especially those that Cuba had to import with hard currency like pesticides, fertilizers, fuel, and farm equipment.[25] Cuban scientists and agricultural economists argued that this was Cuba’s chance to become a world leader in green agriculture, and many outside experts agreed.[26] Cuban farmers, though, were not always happy to be asked to experiment with organic and low-technology solutions. Nevertheless, Laura Enríquez found that more people were moving into agriculture – “repeasantization,” she called it – and that these old and new peasants actually fared somewhat better than the urban population during the economic crisis.[27]

A renewed emphasis on the environment went beyond agriculture. The relationship of environmental consciousness and environmental protection to economic growth and development is not an obvious one. Most environmentalists argue that both capitalist and socialist models of industrialization and economic progress have been based on plundering the natural environment. Much environmental destruction in the Third World has been the result of colonial and neo-colonial plantation agriculture and extractive economies. But socialist Cuba’s agricultural and industrial systems exhibited much of the same environmental recklessness as those in the capitalist world.[28]